

Blaming Bureaucrats

How Political Leadership Shapes Civil Servants' Trust and Engagement

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Abstract

When crises arise, elected officials often try to manage reputational risk through presentational strategies, or explanatory frames that contextualize their roles in creating and/or resolving the crises. We study how these choices reverberate inside government, examining how executives' decisions to accept responsibility or blame subordinate civil servants shape bureaucratic trust and willingness to act on the executive's behalf. Drawing on a pre-registered survey experiment of more than 2,500 state employees in nine US states, we show that civil servants deem executives who deflect blame onto their agencies as less trustworthy and are less willing to exert effort on their behalf. Sharing or accepting responsibility fosters trust, especially when civil servants believe their department bears fault, though the magnitudes of these effects are smaller than those associated with blame deflection. Presentational strategies are not costless: moves that leaders think protect them in the short run can erode civil servants' trust and willingness to cooperate.

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In 2014, the city of Flint, Michigan, under a state-appointed emergency manager, switched its water supply to the Flint River in an effort to cut costs. The river water was so polluted and corrosive that it caused lead to leach from aging pipes into the drinking supply, prompting residents to report discolored water and serious health problems. For over a year, officials at the Michigan Department of Environmental Quality (MDEQ) and the governor’s office downplayed or outright dismissed concerns, despite evidence of contamination from independent scientists and local activists. A state task force later concluded the department failed in its basic responsibility to enforce drinking water regulations (*Final Report*, 2016).

Michigan Governor Rick Snyder apologized for the incident but also shifted responsibility to others—especially the “career bureaucrats” at MDEQ who “made these terrible decisions that showed a clear lack of common sense.”¹ His deflection angered state workers. One MDEQ employee said that Snyder’s accusations toward her department “rang hollow” and that morale was “the worst she’s ever seen it.”² A state-commissioned employee survey in 2017 found that, in the aftermath of the crisis, MDEQ expressed worse morale, sense of direction, trust in department leadership, and engagement with their work than they had two years prior.³

Did Snyder’s decision to cast blame on the bureaucracy make state employees view him as a less credible leader and less willing to act on his behalf? Would their reaction have differed had he instead accepted responsibility? These questions speak to a broader puzzle. Elected executives routinely frame governmental crises for external audiences, but we know little about how civil servants interpret these messages and whether executives’ explanations of failure shape trust and effort within the agencies they oversee. The Flint case suggests presentational choices can reverberate inside government, potentially affecting the administrative capacity on which executives depend.

In this paper, we examine how the presentational strategies elected executives (e.g., presidents, prime ministers, governors, mayors) adopt in the wake of the “blame game” (Hood, 2011) around adverse outcomes—such as the Flint water crisis—shape civil servants’ perceptions of their lead-

¹Egan, Paul. “Gov. Rick Snyder blames ‘career bureaucrats’ for Flint water crisis.” *Detroit Free Press*, March 17, 2016, <https://www.freep.com/story/news/local/michigan/flint-water-crisis/2016/03/17/snyder-blame-water-flint-criss/81900340/>.

²Brush, Mark, Lindsey Smith, and Rebecca Williams. “Will Gov. Snyder change the agency blamed for the Flint water crisis?” *Michigan Public Radio*, June 16, 2016, <https://www.michiganpublic.org/environment-science/2016-06-16/will-gov-snyder-change-the-agency-blamed-for-the-flint-water-crisis>.

³Lawler, Emily. “State employees struggle with morale following Flint water crisis charges.” *MLive*, June 29, 2017, https://www.mlive.com/news/2017/06/flint_water_state_employees.html.

ers. While extant research explores how presentational strategies influence the public, the media, and other elected officials (Boin et al., 2010; Brändström, Kuipers and Daléus, 2008; Hood et al., 2009; Miller and Reeves, 2022; Moynihan, 2012; Nowlan, 2026), far less is known about how they resonate inside government. Civil servants constitute a distinct audience. They are often proximate to adverse outcomes in the policy implementation process, possess information about agency performance, experience consequences of blame firsthand, and rely on executives for support and protection during periods of scrutiny (Hinterleitner, 2026). Executives’ decisions to accept or deflect responsibility may therefore carry consequences for bureaucratic trust, morale, and effort.

We argue executives’ presentational strategies during crisis management signal their trustworthiness to civil servants. Effective leadership depends on civil servants’ willingness to accept and act on executive authority, a willingness shaped in part by trust (Carpenter and Krause, 2015). When an executive blames the bureaucracy, civil servants may view the move as self-protective. Additionally, the agency that is criticized may suffer reputational damage and its employees may face psychological and professional costs. By contrast, when an executive accepts responsibility and shields civil servants from blame, the gesture conveys support in a moment of vulnerability. Civil servants may trust executives who uphold their side of the relationship when things go wrong, consistent with research on leadership credibility and support (Jakobsen, Andersen and van Luttervelt, 2022; Moynihan, Pandey and Wright, 2013).

We evaluate these dynamics using a preregistered survey experiment fielded with more than 2,500 state employees across nine US states—some of the very civil servants who must interpret executive cues when implementing policies. Rather than relying on public opinion or convenience samples, we observe how actual civil servants react to an executive’s crisis messaging. Respondents read a stylized scenario concerning a governmental crisis involving a department for which they work and then encounter various explanations from the governor. The pattern is clear: when the governor claims blame for the failure, civil servants express greater trust in the executive’s leadership. However, when the governor deflects blame to the department, trust falls sharply, and their willingness to carry out her requests declines. Importantly, the magnitude of the negative effects of deflecting blame are two to four times larger than the positive effects of blame claiming, which may reflect negativity bias among civil servants (Hinterleitner, 2026; Hood, 2011) or that deflecting blame transmits a more informative signal of the governor’s trustworthiness because they

implicate the civil servants directly. These reactions also depend on the department’s objective performance. Executives who claim blame are rewarded most when the department had in fact erred, whereas executives who deflect blame are punished most when the department had acted appropriately.

Our findings demonstrate an underrecognized pathway through which chief executives shape their relationship with the administrative state. Presentational strategies used during crises do more than manage public impressions; they communicate to the civil servants who translate executive priorities into action. How executives explain failure signals whether they can be trusted to support their agencies when the stakes are high. Executives who accept responsibility and shield their subordinates signal reliability and support. Executives who shift blame downward send the opposite message, raising doubts about their trustworthiness and reducing civil servants’ willingness to expend effort on their behalf. While relationships between executives and civil servants are built from an accumulation of experiences and moderated by the institutional contexts in which they operate, the impressions formed during a governmental crisis can contribute to those evolving relationships (Hood and Lodge, 2006). By documenting these internal effects, this study broadens the scope of research on crisis communication and reveals how executive rhetoric can strengthen or erode the relational foundations on which executive power rest.

Motivating Bureaucratic Effort

Chief executives—such as presidents, prime ministers, governors, and mayors—pursue goals such as electoral success for themselves and their allies, meaningful policy accomplishments, and a durable legacy (Light, 1998 [1982]). While these leaders enjoy considerable authority, they still require the cooperation of other political actors to realize their priorities (Neustadt, 1960). Even when issuing unilateral directives, they depend on personnel in the executive branch to convert those directives into action (Heclo, 1977; Neustadt, 1960; Rudalevige, 2021; Yackee, 2025). Motivating civil servants to act in accordance with an executive’s will is therefore a central challenge in governance.

Existing scholarship emphasizes the formal tools executives can use to shape bureaucratic behavior. Executives can centralize decision-making, deploy loyal political appointees, and exercise oversight over agency actions (Haeder and Yackee, 2018; Lewis, 2008; Moe, 1985). Yet, as Carpen-

ter and Krause (2015) argues, these institutional levers rarely guarantee compliance (see also Hood and Lodge, 2006). Because the “incomplete contract” between political leaders and civil servants allows for discretion, civil servants can withhold information, reinterpret guidance, or slow implementation through additional review (Potter, 2017; Rudalevige, 2021). Consequently, executives must move beyond formal levers of control and cultivate what Carpenter and Krause (2015) terms “sanctioned acceptance,” a relational foundation in which civil servants recognize the executive’s legitimate authority and are willing to exercise their discretion in ways that advance her goals (Presthus, 1960; Simon, 1957). This sanctioned acceptance serves as an important component of the “public service bargain” that establishes the contours of the politician-bureaucrat dynamic; in exchange for recognizing executives’ authority, civil servants expect executives to afford them discretion over the policies within their domain (Hood and Lodge, 2006).

Chief executives cultivate sanctioned acceptance by building trust with civil servants. They do so by respecting workers’ expertise and by supporting their work by providing resources and political cover (Carpenter and Krause, 2015, 14). Trust also grows when executives and their appointees involve civil servants in decisionmaking and implementation, create opportunities for feedback, and advocate for agencies to audiences such as other executive branch actors, legislators, stakeholders, and the public (Heclo, 1977). These efforts speak directly to the public service motivation that draws many into government. Civil servants seek to influence policymaking and fulfill their civic obligations, and they develop a greater affinity for executives who enable them to pursue those aims (Christensen, Paarlberg and Perry, 2017; Grøn and Salomonsen, 2019; Perry and Wise, 1990; Perry, 1996). When civil servants perceive that elected officials trust and support them, they become more committed to implementing the policies supported by those officials (Yang and Pandey 2009; see also Hameduddin and Fernandez 2019; Macey and Schneider 2008). Civil servants who trust their elected and appointed managers also sense greater ability to build intellectual capital capacity, an important antecedent to effective policy implementation (Resh, 2015). Compassion from superiors further reduces burnout, strengthens commitment, and increases willingness to undertake demanding tasks that advance agency output (Eldor, 2018).

Executives erode sanctioned acceptance when they violate the terms of the public service bargain by criticizing or scapegoating the very agencies they rely on (Hood and Lodge, 2006). When chief executives engage in bureaucrat bashing, they undermine trust and lower civil servants’ willingness

to exert effort on behalf of executives and their appointees (Garrett et al. 2006; see also Li et al. 2024; Hinterleitner 2026; Schyns and Schilling 2013). While public service bargains typically require civil servants to shoulder some of the blame associated with adverse outcomes, civil servants are likely to react negatively to executives who violate norms surrounding the expected distribution of blame. In interviews, civil servants indicated that when their political superiors publicly blamed them for mistakes, this “withdrawal of ‘love and respect’ would be matched by a corresponding reduction in loyalty” (Hood and Lodge, 2006, 120). Through routine interactions, civil servants develop beliefs about the trustworthiness of their elected leaders and how well those executives are upholding the public service bargain between them. Those beliefs shape the extent to which executives can motivate the bureaucracy to carry out their priorities. Taken together, these perspectives point to a common mechanism: executives’ presentational strategies provide information that civil servants use to update their assessments of whether the executive can be trusted to uphold the public service bargain.

Importantly, political appointees often mediate the relationship between elected executives and civil servants. Because civil servants are more proximate to appointees in agency hierarchies and interact with them more frequently, appointees can shape how civil servants interpret executives’ words and actions, and executives may rely on them to cultivate civil servants’ trust (Heclo, 1977; Resh, 2015). However, since appointees are ultimately proxies of the executive, selected in part for their loyalty and reliant on the executive’s support for continuance in office, civil servants can be skeptical of their credibility as messengers and question the information they present (Lewis, 2008; Resh, 2015). Crucially, civil servants are often able to draw on other sources of information to help them form assessments of their executives. For instance, because news about elected officials is increasingly easy to access and civil servants are more knowledgeable and attentive to political news than the general public, they are better able to observe executives’ public behavior directly through the media (Ertas, 2015). Additionally, at lower levels of government, including states, cities, and towns, fewer organizational layers often allow civil servants to interact more frequently with executives and form independent judgments about them (Grøn and Salomonsen, 2019).⁴ Thus,

⁴Even at higher levels of government, executives’ behavior can directly inform civil servants’ perceptions. For example, Senior Executive Service members in the federal government felt undervalued when President Obama waited until his second term to meet with them, unlike previous presidents who met with them early in their first terms (Resh, 2015, 157–158).

while political appointees are important mediators between executives and civil servants, civil servants also acquire information directly from executives that informs their perceptions of them.

Governmental Crises Opportunities to Cultivate or Erode Trust

The importance of trust becomes even sharper when governments confront failure. Crises invite public scrutiny, trigger blame games, and test the relationships between executives and their agencies. Governmental crises are important opportunities for civil servants to learn about their executives' trustworthiness. While an executive's behavior in a single crisis may not determine how civil servants perceive her, it can lead them to reassess whether the executive is worthy of the legitimacy they confer upon her and how well she is upholding her side of the public service bargain.

No matter how well prepared a government is, *governmental crises*—adverse outcomes stemming from government action or inaction and attracting public attention—inevitably arise (Miller and Reeves, 2022). Such crises range from failures to prevent fraud, to leaks of sensitive information, to the mismanagement of natural disasters. When they occur, political actors, the media, and the public quickly search for someone to blame, and elected executives are frequent targets. Formally, chief executives hold ultimate responsibility for the conduct of government (Bovens, 2007, 458). Socialization reinforces this formal role: the public routinely expects executives to be responsible for a wide set of outcomes (Clifford et al., 2024). Presidents, for example, are expected to do “something about everything” (Neustadt, 1960, 7), and the accumulation of statutory responsibilities over time fuels the mythic expectation that they can meet those demands (Lowi, 1985, 151). Governors face similar expectations (Kousser and Phillips, 2012, 251), and executives across all levels are judged for broad agency performance (Ansolabehere, Gerber and Snyder, 2002, 315). These formal responsibilities and socialized expectations place executives at the center of the blame games that follow crises (Boin, McConnell and T'Hart, 2008; Hood, 2011; Weaver, 1986).

Because elected executives derive much of their power and influence from the reputations they cultivate among other political elites, the media, and the public (Neustadt, 1960), blame games are dangerous circumstances that can tarnish their reputations if they are ultimately held responsible for the underlying governmental crisis (Boin, McConnell and T'Hart, 2008; Hinterleitner and Sager, 2017; Hood, 2011; Resodihardjo, 2020). Once a blame game is active and an elected executive is

a target, they often turn to presentational strategies to try to navigate the crisis and preserve their reputation (Hood, 2011). These strategies typically involve the executive’s choice to accept or deflect blame for the crisis. On the one hand, if an executive can avoid blame, they may expect to escape association with the adverse outcome and the negative perceptions that accompany it. However, if they accept blame, they could improve perceptions of their leadership valence by presenting themselves as willing to take responsibility when adverse outcomes occur (Miller and Reeves, 2022).

While academic studies of the implications of presentational strategies typically focus on how they shape perceptions of the public, the media, other elected officials, or political parties (e.g., Boin et al., 2010; Brändström, Kuipers and Daléus, 2008; Hood et al., 2009; Miller and Reeves, 2022; Moynihan, 2012; Nowlan, 2026), we focus on the effects of these strategies on an underappreciated audience—the civil servants who are formally responsible to those executives and are often also implicated in the governmental crisis. Critically, because civil servants, through their role of implementing government policy on behalf of the executive, are often more proximate to the crisis, they are often plausible targets for blame, and in crafting their presentational strategies executives often consider the role of the civil servants who are formally responsible to them (Hinterleitner, 2026). Additionally, because civil servants lack direct connections to the electorate and are formally subordinate to the executive, they lack independent channels through which to offer their own presentational strategies when crises strike; rather, they rely on the executive’s account of their culpability to shape public perceptions of their agencies (Hinterleitner 2026; Hood 2011; but see Grube 2019). Civil servants, therefore, monitor executive messaging closely, as these signals reveal whether they can expect political support or scapegoating after failures—information that directly affects their professional standing and organizational reputation. Thus, how executives incorporate the bureaucracy into their presentational strategies can help civil servants assess the trustworthiness of those executives.

One straightforward presentational strategy available to elected executives is to deflect blame for the governmental crisis to civil servants. In doing so, executives utilize civil servants as “lightning rods” who absorb blame while allowing executives to preserve their own reputations in the eyes of other political figures, the media, and the public (Ellis, 1994). In most public service bargains, civil servants expect to be susceptible to some degree of blame when adverse outcomes arise, particularly

because the discretion executives grant them over their policy area increases their responsibility for subsequent adverse outcomes (Hood and Lodge, 2006). However, this strategy risks damaging the trust they have with their civil servants, which can undermine their ability to manage the executive branch, especially if the blame the executive assigns exceeds what civil servants regard as appropriate under the public service bargain. First, because civil servants fiercely value their agencies’ reputations, as they help them gain discretion in carrying out their missions, cultivate legitimacy in the eyes of other political actors and the public, and bolster their own satisfaction with their jobs (Carpenter, 2001; Moynihan, 2012; Pedersen et al., 2025), they should react negatively to acts that undercut their agencies’ reputations and perceive an executive who sacrifices them to protect herself as selfish and untrustworthy (Hinterleitner, 2026). Second, because blame exacts psychic and physical costs on those who incur it (Hastorf, Schneider and Polefka, 1970; Zuckerman, 1979), civil servants to whom executives deflect blame are likely to resent executives who heap those costs upon them and encourage bureaucrat bashing that diminishes morale (Garrett et al., 2006; Jahan and Shahan, 2012; Lotta, Tavares and Story, 2024; Hinterleitner, 2026). Thus, we expect that when elected executives deflect blame to civil servants, civil servants will view them as less trustworthy and be less willing to exert effort on their behalf.

While deflecting blame to others is a prominent presentational strategy, it is not the only option elected executives implicated in a blame game have. Rather than trying to escape responsibility, executives can instead embrace the saying immortalized by a placard US President Harry S Truman kept on his desk in the Oval Office—“the buck stops here”—and accept blame for a crisis. While executives and commentators often expect this to hurt their reputations (but see Miller and Reeves, 2022), it can not only make executives look like better leaders, but also provide civil servants with signals about their trustworthiness—especially if in claiming blame the executive absorbs blame *away* from the bureaucracy. When executives claim blame, they not only risk making themselves politically vulnerable, but also take on the personal psychic and physical costs of taking responsibility for adverse outcomes. These self-sacrifices can bolster executives’ reputations among civil servants as leaders worthy of their trust because they stand by their subordinates, even when things go wrong (Busuioc and Lodge, 2016, 2017; Hood, 2011; Thompson, 1980). Further, executives’ willingness to protect civil servants from blame signals whether they can be trusted to support their agencies when adverse outcomes arise. By accepting responsibility, executives demonstrate a

willingness to bear costs on behalf of their subordinates, reinforcing the trust that underpins effective politician-bureaucrat relationships (Jakobsen, Andersen and van Luttervelt, 2022; Moynihan, Pandey and Wright, 2013; Oberfield, 2014). Thus, we expect that when elected executives employ presentational strategies that claim blame for themselves, civil servants will view those executives as more trustworthy and be more willing to exert effort on their behalf.⁵

The Role of Culpability in Civil Servants’ Reactions to Executives’ Presentational Strategies

Blame games and the presentational strategies elected executives employ to navigate them do not occur in vacuums; rather, the circumstances surrounding a governmental crisis can affect how external audiences receive those presentational strategies. One consideration that can condition the effect of the executive’s presentational strategy on civil servants’ perceptions of her is the objective responsibility of the executive and the bureaucracy for the crisis. Recent work suggests culpability conditions how external audiences evaluate blame shifting. Nowlan (2026), for example, finds that citizens are more accepting of elected officials shifting blame for public service failures when they perceive the service provider as relatively more culpable. We extend this logic inside government by considering whether civil servants themselves evaluate executives’ blame allocations against their understanding of their agency’s responsibility for the failure. When trying to make sense of events, civil servants, like all individuals, have both directional and accuracy goals that encourage them to reach conclusions that accord with their worldview and are “correct,” respectively (Bolsen and Palm, 2019; Kunda, 1990). In the context of attributing responsibility after a governmental crisis, while civil servants have directional motivations to evade blame, they also face competing accuracy motivations to discern how blame *should* be allocated. Given their public service motivation, civil servants seek out information about their performance, even if it is negative, in order to make sure their agencies are fulfilling their missions and making a positive impact on society (Christensen, Paarlberg and Perry, 2017; Perry and Wise, 1990; Perry, 1996; Van der Voet, 2023).

⁵While we present blame deflecting and blame claiming as orthogonal strategies, executives can employ “mixed” strategies; for instance, the executive may claim some of the blame but also allocate some to a bureaucratic agency. Because this strategy of sharing blame combines the positive reputational effects of the executive demonstrating willingness to support her subordinates with the negative effects of diminishing the agency’s reputation and making civil servants incur the psychic and physical costs of blame, we also pre-registered that when executives share blame with civil servants, their trust in those executives and willingness to exert effort on their behalf will be higher than when the executives deflect all of the blame to them, but lower than when the executives claimed all of the blame.

Further, Garrett et al. (2006) share that while civil servants dislike bureaucrat bashing from outside audiences, they expend effort to discern whether such bashing is justified. Given their proximity to the crisis, civil servants are likely to have information that helps them form an impression of how blameworthy they truly are—even if those impressions reflect poorly on themselves (Schlenker et al., 1994).

How well an elected executive’s allocation of blame in their presentational strategy corresponds with civil servants’ impression of their own blameworthiness likely conditions how civil servants react to the executive’s words. Suppose first a crisis stemmed from civil servants’ action or inaction such that they deserve blame. If the executive attributes blame to civil servants for the crisis, civil servants will have a natural adverse reaction to receiving blame but recognize that they are responsible for the outcome, thus dampening the negative effects of the executive blaming them on their perceptions of her (Hood and Lodge, 2006; Markman and Tetlock, 2000; Schlenker et al., 1994). If instead the executive shields civil servants from blame they rightly deserve by claiming it for herself, she signals to them that she is a supportive leader, prompting them to place more trust in her and to be more willing to exert effort on her behalf (Busuioc and Lodge, 2016, 2017; Hood, 2011; Thompson, 1980). Indeed, as the civil servants interviewed by Hood and Lodge relay, politicians “who backed civil servants when they made mistakes could expect to be rewarded by dog-like loyalty” (2006, 120).

Now suppose the bureaucracy is not primarily responsible for the crisis, but that some other person, organization, or act of God prompted the adverse outcome. If the executive, as the unitary figure with ultimate responsibility for the conduct of government, claims the blame for the crisis, she makes a functionally accurate allocation of blame that signals her type as a trustworthy leader while shielding civil servants from undeserved criticism. However, were the executive to deflect blame to the bureaucracy, civil servants would incur not only reputational damage to their agencies and psychic and physical costs associated with blame, but also the indignity and resentment of being made to shoulder responsibility for a crisis that was not their doing because the executive “cheat[ed]” on their public service bargain by “blam[ing] them for their own failings” (Hood and Lodge 2006, 164; see also Schlenker et al. 1994).

Thus, we expect that the effect of executives’ presentational strategies that address blame for the crisis on civil servants’ perceptions of those executives is conditioned by the correspondence of

the civil servants’ true degree of blameworthiness and the degree of blame the executive attributes to them. Specifically, the effect of blame claiming on civil servants’ trust in and willingness to work on behalf of an executive is larger when the civil servants are culpable for the crisis, as the executive shields them from blame they know they deserve, thus selflessly sparing them the costs associated with blame. Further, the effect of blame deflecting is larger when civil servants are not responsible for the crisis, as the executive’s deflection not only prompts civil servants to incur the consequences of blame, but does so when their performance does not warrant it; thus, civil servants perceive the executive does not value their service and expertise, eroding their trust in and willingness to exert effort for her.⁶

Experimental Evidence from Civil Servants in the US States

Studying how individual civil servants respond to the words and actions of elected executives presents two key challenges. First, most civil servants work outside public view and rarely advertise their opinions about internal deliberations or their political principles, making their responses hard to observe. If a governor criticizes an agency, the ways that criticism influences civil servants’ attitudes toward the executive and their subsequent behavior would likely remain hidden.

Second, even if researchers could observe these responses across many cases, isolating the causal effect of any given presentational strategy would be difficult. Suppose researchers could observe civil servants’ responses to mayors’ comments during governmental crises across American cities, and civil servants expressed more favorable views toward mayors who took responsibility rather than those who blamed subordinates. While this pattern might suggest that mayors’ rhetoric causally affects civil servants’ perceptions, alternative explanations would be difficult to rule out. Other factors related to mayors’ decisions to accept blame, such as crisis severity or pre-existing relationships with civil servants, could instead explain the differences in attitudes.

To address these research design challenges, we utilize an original survey experiment of civil servants in 9 US states. By fielding a survey, we can directly collect information about civil servants’ perceptions of political principals that they typically do not express publicly. Within

⁶Our pre-registration document stated that we would examine how the objective blameworthiness of the civil servant’s department conditions the effects of elected executives’ presentational strategies, but we did not provide explicit statements about *how* these conditional effects would manifest. Thus, this set of expectations is exploratory.

the survey, we include an experiment featuring a stylized vignette that systematically varies an elected executive’s rhetoric—whether they accept blame for a governmental crisis or deflect it to civil servants—and the actions of their agency while holding other dimensions constant across respondents. We opt for a stylized vignette, which we describe below, rather than one involving the respondent’s own civil service experience because it enables us to control for idiosyncratic features of the respondent’s own state, agency, or political leaders and attribute any observed differences in civil servants’ perceptions of the featured executive to the executive’s choice of presentational strategy (Gaines, Kuklinski and Quirk, 2007). Additionally, using a stylized vignette enables us to present the same scenario to all respondents that systematically varies only the executive’s rhetoric and their agency’s actions without employing deception. While the stylized vignette abstracts away some important dimensions of civil servants’ relationships with elected executives, recent studies suggest that experiments utilizing abstraction typically yield results similar to those using more realistic stimuli (Brutger et al., 2023; Suong, Desposato and Gartzke, 2023).

We embedded our pre-registered survey experiment in a survey of US state civil servants fielded between May 31 and June 26, 2024.⁷ The sampling frame for this survey contained all state government employees whose email addresses were posted publicly in the directories of the following nine states: Connecticut, Florida, Illinois, Indiana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, North Carolina, Oregon, and Vermont.⁸ Of the 219,103 persons with valid email addresses in the sampling frame, 2,540 completed the survey module in which our experiment was embedded, yielding a response rate of 1.2% ($\frac{2,540}{219,103}$).^{9,10}

⁷Our pre-analysis plan is available at the Open Science Framework: https://osf.io/9v8ga/overview?view_only=1fe35c1e117a4e9787e06a06ad733bd7. The institutional review board at [REDACTED] approved the survey in which the experiment was embedded.

⁸At the time we surveyed data availability in late 2021, 25 states publicly provided contact information for their state employees. We selected these 9 states because they were both feasible to collect given the structure of their employee directories and because they provide variation on important political, socioeconomic, and cultural dimensions that may inform the preferences and behaviors of civil servants, such as the states’ geographic location and size, the partisan affiliation of the states’ governors and legislative majorities, and the relative size of different racial and ethnic groups among the states’ populations. See Supplemental Information Section B.1 for more information on the selection of states and collection of contact information.

⁹While our response rate is lower than that of other recently published survey experiments with American elite samples (Furnas and LaPira, 2024; Miller, 2022), it is comparable to response rates for surveys of American mass public samples (e.g., “Voters Broadly Positive About How Elections Were Conducted, in Sharp Contrast to 2020.” *Pew Research Center*, December 4, 2024, https://www.pewresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/20/2024/12/PP_2024.12.3_election-2024_REPORT.pdf) and the size of our sampling frame ensured we would obtain enough respondents to conduct well-powered analyses. We suspect our response rate is a consequence of state government employees having been socialized by information technology professionals to be skeptical of emails from unfamiliar senders (see Supplemental Information Section A).

¹⁰Please see Supplemental Information Section B.3 for the descriptive characteristics of our respondents and how

In the survey, respondents were asked to imagine working for a transportation department in another state. Then, respondents were presented with a short vignette describing a recent major snowstorm that caused significant traffic delays and several car accidents on the state’s roadways, prompting legislators, journalists, and the public to criticize the state’s handling of the storm.¹¹ Next, respondents saw an excerpt from a press conference the governor held in which the governor addressed the criticism surrounding the traffic problems prompted by the snowstorm and pledged to review how the state responds to snowstorms to avoid similar problems in the future.

Two facets of the survey experiment were independently randomized across respondents. The first varied how the governor allocated blame for the state’s handling of the snowstorm. Respondents in the control group read that the governor told reporters it was “too early to place blame for why the state’s roadways were in such poor condition.” In the three treatment conditions, respondents read that the governor employed one of three presentational strategies to attribute responsibility. In the *Blame Claim* condition, the governor declared, “I am ultimately responsible for the management of state roadways, and I accept blame for this situation.” In the *Blame Deflect* condition, the governor argues that, “the state’s department of transportation is ultimately responsible for the management of state roadways, and they are to blame for this situation.” Beyond strict blame claiming and blame deflecting, we also include a third treatment condition in which the governor *shares* blame with the department. In doing so, we acknowledge that executives sometimes blend these strategies in an attempt to reap the benefits of both (Hood, 2011). In this *Blame Share* condition, the governor states that, “I share responsibility with the state’s department of transportation for the management of state roadways, and I accept some of the blame for this situation.” These statements vary in the degree to which the governor accepted or redirected blame to the state’s transportation department.

the characteristics of our respondents compare to those of state-level civil servants in the states where they work. In general, our respondents tend to be older and have more years of experience working in state government when compared to the full populations of state employees; however, we find little evidence of heterogeneous effects associated with these characteristics in Supplemental Information Section C, mitigating concern that the composition of our sample produces substantially different average treatment effects than would be obtained from a fully representative sample (Coppock, 2019).

¹¹We sought to describe a governmental crisis that civil servants in any state could plausibly imagine confronting. Although snowstorms occur more often in some regions than others, nearly every US state experiences snowfall (Dolce, Chris. “All 50 States Have Seen Snow This Winter and Some Southern Cities Have Topped Northern Ones.” *The Weather Channel*, January 23, 2025, <https://weather.com/storms/winter/news/2025-01-22-50-states-snowfall-winter-southern-cities-top-northern-cities>). States that experience snow less frequently may also face greater challenges managing storms, making the risk of governmental failure salient even in states such as Florida.

Second, we randomized the information respondents learned about the transportation department’s preparedness. In the control condition, the vignette did not report whether the department anticipated the storm’s magnitude or deployed sufficient resources, leaving its preparedness ambiguous. In the *Prepared* condition, respondents read that the department “correctly assessed the severity of the storm and deployed the appropriate number of crews to treat and clear the roads.” In the *Underprepared* condition, they read that the department “underestimated the severity of the storm and deployed fewer crews to treat and clear the roads than was necessary.” This element of the design varied the extent to which the department was objectively blameworthy.

After reading the vignette, we present respondents with four outcome questions that capture key dimensions of the executive–civil servant relationship. Because our theory holds that presentational strategies shape both civil servants’ trust in the executive and their willingness to exert discretionary effort, we measure outcomes that reflect these two components of sanctioned acceptance.

The first two questions asked respondents to rate, on a five-point scale, the extent to which they trusted the governor to defend their department against warranted and unwarranted criticism. These items capture whether civil servants believe the governor will provide political cover, a critical form of support when organizations encounter public scrutiny. Next, respondents were asked, again on a five-point scale, how much effort they expect the governor to invest in supporting their department’s mission and activities. This item measures perceptions of administrative support—the governor’s willingness to allocate time, attention, and resources to support the department’s success (Bednar and Lewis, 2024). Finally, respondents were asked to imagine that the governor requested their participation on a task force to review the state’s snowstorm response plans, and to indicate on a four-point scale how likely they would be to serve. This final item prompts our respondents to move beyond the evaluative considerations gauged by the first three questions and instead consider their willingness to expend effort on the governor’s behalf. Taken together, these questions assess respondents’ appraisal of whether the governor is a reliable partner who will protect and advance the department’s work and is worthy of subordinates’ effort—important signals of the trust civil servants place in elected executives. Figure 1 presents a schematic diagram of our survey experiment.

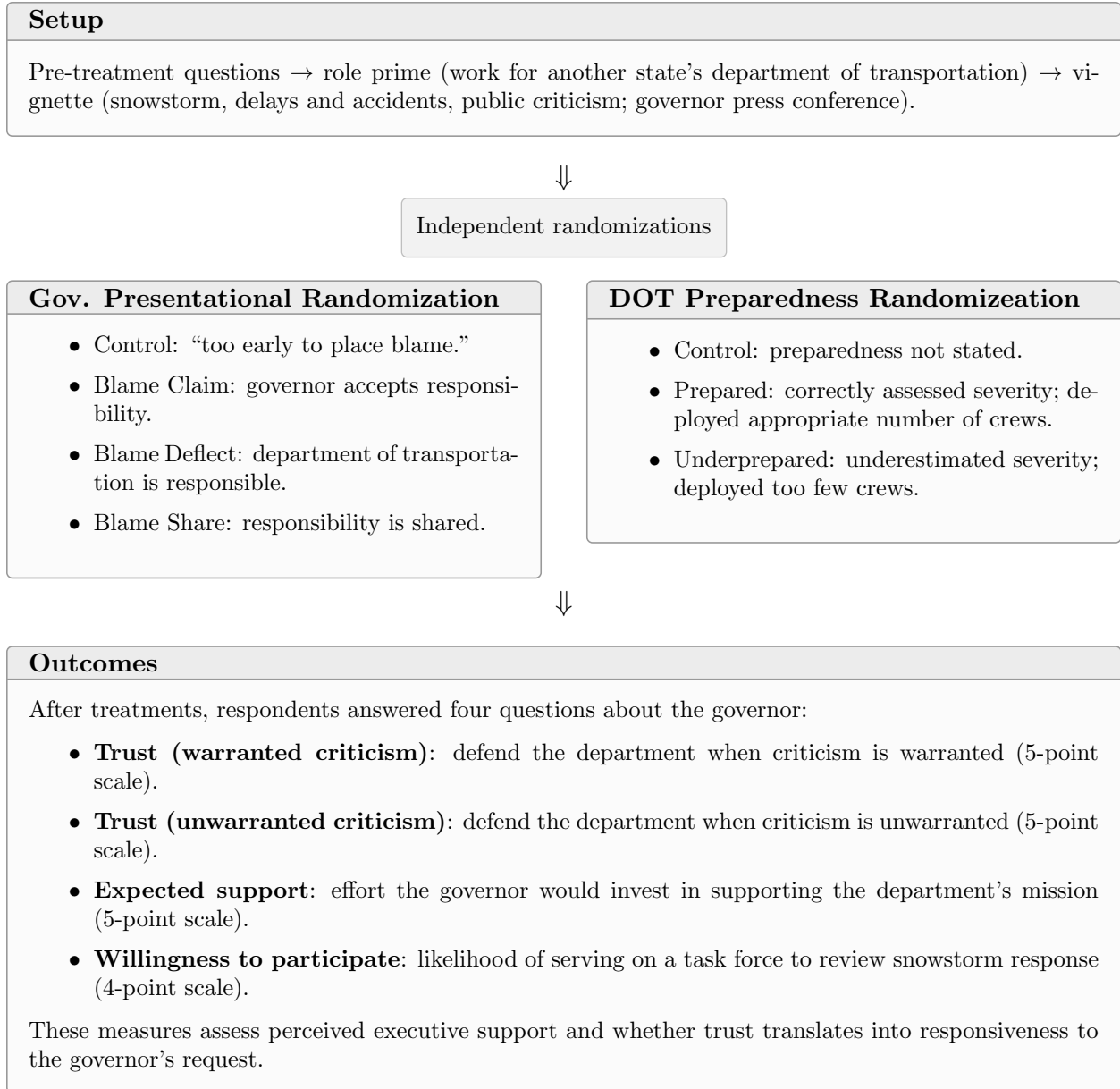


Figure 1: Schematic of Experimental Randomization and Outcomes

Results

We begin by examining the effects of each presentational strategy—*Blame Claim*, *Blame Deflect*, and *Blame Share*—on the four outcome measures, irrespective of the department’s objective performance, in Figure 2. All effects, estimated using linear regression, are expressed relative to the control condition, in which the governor stated that it was too early to assign blame. Higher values indicate more favorable views of the governor.

Focusing first on respondents’ trust that the governor would defend their department from either unwarranted (Figure 2, row 1) or warranted (Figure 2, row 2) criticism, a similar pattern appears across both outcomes. Respondents in the *Blame Claim* condition (circles) report higher levels of trust compared to the control group. Conversely, those in the *Blame Deflect* condition (squares) report the opposite. Finally, in the *Blame Share* condition (triangles) show a modestly more positive assessment than the control group; though these differences are generally small and not statistically distinguishable from those in the control group, they are distinguishable from the sharply negative reactions observed when the governor deflects blame.

Further, the relative magnitudes of these effects are striking. For unwarranted criticism, respondents in the *Blame Claim* condition rate their trust 0.17 points higher on the five-point scale than respondents in the control condition. Meanwhile, those in the *Blame Deflect* condition rate their trust 0.79 points lower. The nearly one-point difference separating *Blame Claim* and *Blame Deflect* represents a meaningful shift in perceptions of the governor’s willingness to defend the department. Results for warranted criticism are comparable: *Blame Claim* increases trust by 0.23 points relative to control, whereas *Blame Deflect* decreases trust by 0.59 points. As we describe in our conclusion, this asymmetry may stem from civil servants’ innate negativity bias or from more direct implications of the *Blame Deflect* message for the department’s reputation.

These findings demonstrate that civil servants use executives’ presentational strategies as cues about whether leaders can be trusted to support the agency during public scrutiny. Executives who accept responsibility—and thereby shield agencies from reputational, psychic, and physical costs—are rewarded with greater trust. Executives who redirect those costs downward are penalized. In this way, even brief responses to a crisis can inform the relational foundation that underpins bureaucratic cooperation.

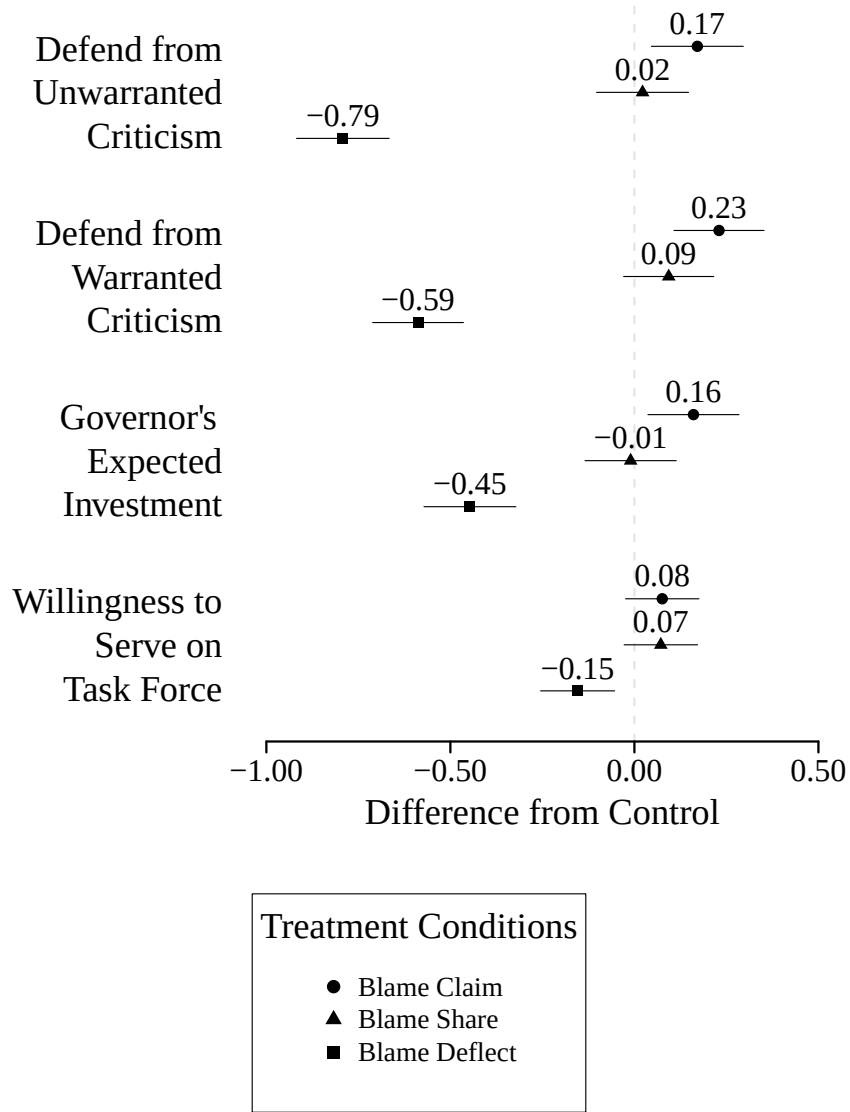


Figure 2: **Effects of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategy on Civil Servants' Perceptions of the Governor.** Linear regression coefficients for treatment effects of the Blame Claim (circles), Blame Share (triangles), and Blame Deflect (squares) conditions. Outcomes concerning respondents' expectations of the governor's willingness to defend their department from unwarranted or warranted criticism and to invest in their department are measured using five-point scales, while the outcome concerning respondents' willingness to serve on a task force to review the state's snowstorm response plans is measured using a four-point scale. Bars around point estimates represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

We observe a similar pattern when examining respondents' expectations that the governor would invest effort in supporting the department's mission and activities. Respondents assigned to the *Blame Claim* condition report slightly higher expectations of gubernatorial support, rating the governor 0.16 points higher on the five-point scale than those in the control group. By contrast,

those exposed to *Blame Deflect* anticipate meaningfully less support, rating the governor 0.45 points lower, and the magnitude of the negative effect of *Blame Deflect* again overshadows that of the positive effect of *Blame Claim*. Expectations in the *Blame Share* condition remain substantively small and statistically indistinguishable from the control condition, though they are distinguishably more positive than those in the *Blame Deflect* condition.

A related pattern emerges for respondents' stated willingness to expend effort on the governor's behalf. When asked whether they would serve on a task force to review the state's snow-storm response, respondents in the *Blame Deflect* condition report modestly lower willingness to participate—0.15 points lower on the four-point scale—relative to the control group. We find no evidence that exposure to *Blame Claim* or *Blame Share* meaningfully increases or decreases willingness to serve relative to the control group. The point estimates for both conditions are positive but small, while the negative effect of *Blame Deflect* is approximately twice as large.

Conditional Role of Preparedness

We next examine whether the effects of the governor's presentational strategy depend on the department's objective performance. Civil servants are often well-positioned to assess their agency's responsibility for a crisis and may evaluate the governor's allocation of blame against their own understanding of what occurred. The effects of presentational strategies should therefore depend on the agency's objective performance.

Figure 3 presents these conditional effects for the *Blame Claim* (circles), *Blame Deflect* (triangles), and *Blame Share* (squares) treatments among respondents assigned to the *Underprepared* (left panel), *Control* (center panel), and *Prepared* (right panel) conditions. Each estimate is relative to respondents in the corresponding preparedness condition who received no presentational statement from the governor.

Focusing first on *Blame Claim* (circles), we observe that its effects are positive across all preparedness conditions but are largest when the department was described as underprepared. For instance, respondents who read that the governor accepted responsibility and that their department was underprepared rated the governor's expected investment in their department 0.33 points higher than those in the corresponding control condition. When the department was described as

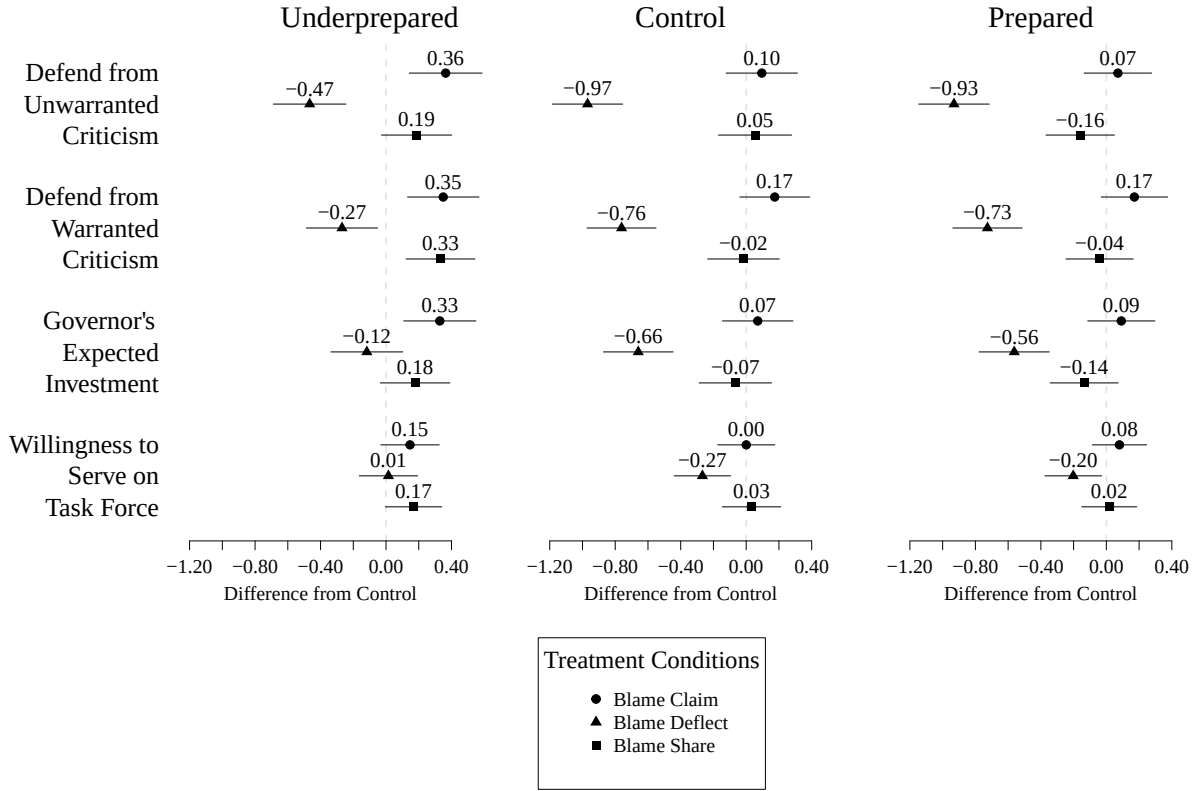


Figure 3: **Effects of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategy on Civil Servants' Perceptions of the Governor, Conditioned by Department Preparedness.** Linear regression coefficients for treatment effects of the *Blame Claim* (circles), *Blame Deflect* (triangles), and *Blame Share* (squares) conditions among respondents assigned to the Underprepared (left panel), Control (center panel), and Prepared (right panel) conditions. In each panel, the baseline to which treatment effects are compared is respondents for whom the governor did not address blame for the state's handling of the snowstorm and the department's level of preparedness was set to the value indicated by the panel title. Outcomes concerning respondents' expectations of the governor's willingness to defend their department from unwarranted or warranted criticism and to invest in their department are measured using five-point scales, while the outcome concerning respondents' willingness to serve on a task force to review the state's snowstorm response plans is measured using a four-point scale. Bars around point estimates represent 95 percent confidence intervals.

adequately prepared, the effect of blame claiming is smaller—an increase of 0.09 points.¹² These results suggest that blame claiming is particularly effective when it shields civil servants from blame they know they deserve. In such cases, the executive's acceptance of responsibility conveys a willingness to absorb political costs on behalf of the agency, signaling support that can strengthen trust and reinforce the relational foundations of the public service bargain.

Next, blame deflection (triangles) produces a clear and consistent pattern of negative results. Across preparedness conditions and outcome measures, shifting blame onto the department reduces

¹² Across outcomes, the effect of blame claiming when the department was underprepared is not statistically distinguishable from the effect when the department was adequately prepared or when preparedness was unspecified. The

trust in the governor and lowers expectations of administrative support. Yet the magnitude of these effects depends sharply on whether civil servants believe they are at fault. Respondents told their department was underprepared reacted negatively to blame deflection, but respondents told their department was adequately prepared reacted far more harshly. For instance, respondents in the *Blame Deflect* condition told their department was underprepared were 0.47 units (on a five-point scale) less trusting that the governor would defend the department from unwarranted criticism, whereas the corresponding estimate among those told the department was adequately prepared was -0.93 . A similar pattern appears for expectations of the governor’s investment in the department: the negative effect is nearly five times larger when the department is adequately prepared (a decrease of 0.56 points) than when it is underprepared (a decrease of 0.12 points).¹³ These results underscore that civil servants consistently punish executives who deflect blame, but they respond most severely when they perceive the blame to be undeserved. In such cases, blame deflection imposes reputational, psychological, and physical costs on civil servants that they believe they do not deserve, signaling that the governor is unwilling to protect the department and is prepared to sacrifice subordinates to safeguard her own standing.

Finally, blame sharing produces a pattern of results similar to, though weaker than, blame claiming. Respondents react most favorably to blame sharing when the department was underprepared, although the effects associated with *Blame Share* are generally not statistically distinguishable from the control condition. However, the pattern across preparedness conditions suggests that civil servants respond more favorably to blame sharing when the governor partially absorbs responsibility for a failure to which their agency contributed relative to when the agency was adequately prepared.¹⁴ In this sense, blame sharing functions as a muted form of blame claiming.

Conclusion

Taken together, our results show that the presentational strategies executives use during crises shape how civil servants perceive them. When executives deflect blame to the bureaucracy, civil

point estimates, however, follow the theoretically expected ordering.

¹³The effect of blame deflection in the *Underprepared* condition is distinguishably smaller than in the *Prepared* and control conditions at the 95 percent level for all outcomes except willingness to serve on the task force, for which the differences are distinguishable at the 90 percent level.

¹⁴Among those assigned to the *Blame Share* condition, the treatment effect associated with *Underprepared* is

servants view them as less trustworthy and become less willing to expend effort on their behalf. When executives instead claim blame, civil servants evaluate them more favorably, especially when their agency bears responsibility for the failure. Civil servants thus care not only about whether executives assign blame to them, but also whether they believe that blame is deserved. How executives explain failure provides civil servants with information about whether they can be trusted to support the agencies they oversee. While the effects we estimate concentrate on how civil servants react to this information in the midst of crisis, their reactions can reverberate beyond the immediate episode by shaping the motivational landscape within agencies, altering how civil servants understand their obligations to elected leaders, and affecting the executive’s ability to marshal the administrative state towards her priorities.

Our findings highlight the relational foundations of bureaucratic accountability. Political control of the bureaucracy does not operate solely through formal authority, monitoring, or sanctions. It also depends on expectations between political leaders and civil servants about responsibility, discretion, and support. This makes accountability potentially double-edged. Executives need to hold civil servants responsible for failures, but how they do so can affect the trust and cooperation on which their ability to govern depends. Blame that civil servants regard as warranted may be consistent with the public service bargain. Blame that appears opportunistic or undeserved, however, can signal that the executive is willing to violate that bargain for political advantage. Public criticism can also encourage anticipatory blame avoidance, leading civil servants to neglect difficult policy problems or avoid innovation (Tu, 2024). Additionally, when executives blame civil servants for outcomes for which they are not responsible, they may erode not only trust but also the legitimacy civil servants attach to executive authority, making subsequent efforts to secure accountability and responsiveness more difficult (Overman and Schillemans, 2022). Accountability and bureaucratic responsiveness are therefore jointly negotiated features of the politician–bureaucrat relationship: efforts to strengthen one can alter the relational foundations supporting the other.

Our results also reveal a notable asymmetry in how civil servants respond to different presentational strategies. Across our outcomes, the negative effects of blame deflection are two to four times as large as the positive effects of blame claiming (see Figure 2). Because we did not pre-

distinguishable from the treatment effect associated with *Prepared* for the following outcome variables: Defend from Unwarranted Criticism, Defend from Warranted Criticism, and Governor’s Expected Investment.

register expectations about relative effect sizes, we are cautious about explaining this pattern, but two possibilities stand out. First, the asymmetry may reflect negativity bias. Individuals tend to weigh negative information more heavily than positive information (e.g., Kahneman and Tversky, 1979), and civil servants may be especially attentive to negative information because they expect political leaders and the public to punish poor performance more readily than they reward strong performance (Albrecht et al., 2026; Hinterleitner, 2026; Hood, 2011; James and Moseley, 2014; Nielsen and Moynihan, 2017). Given civil servants’ motivation to protect their agency’s reputation (Carpenter, 2001), these imbalanced expectations for how external audiences will evaluate them may make civil servants more sensitive to receiving than evading blame, prompting a strong negative reaction when their executive deflects blame to them. Second, blame deflection may provide a clearer signal about an executive’s disposition toward an agency. An executive who publicly blames an agency demonstrates a willingness to expose that agency and its employees to reputational and personal costs, and civil servants on the receiving end may interpret this as a sign of distrust and update negatively about the executive (Hood and Lodge, 2006; Resh, 2015). Alternatively, an executive who claims blame shields the agency from those costs but does not necessarily reveal how she evaluates its performance. Blame deflection may therefore give civil servants more reason to update their views of the executive than blame claiming does. Future research should examine the mechanisms underlying this asymmetry.

While our experiment reveals important causal evidence about how elected executives’ presentational strategies inform civil servants’ perceptions of them, it, like all experiments, does not account for all features of the context in which civil servants exist, which may impose limits for external validity. For some of these missing features, we can probe potential implications by examining how respondents with and without certain background characteristics respond to our stimuli, as the presence of heterogeneous effects may indicate our sample average treatment effects differ from the population average treatment effects (Coppock, 2019). For instance, our respondents may have interpreted our vignette and the governor’s presentational strategy differently given how much control executives exercise over the bureaucracy in their state, how common major snowstorms are in their state, or whether respondents have professional experience with transportation or emergency management.¹⁵ In Supplemental Information Section C, we examine whether treatment effects

¹⁵Our vignette’s focus on snowstorms and transportation raises an additional question about whether our findings

vary with respondents' civil service protections, exposure to severe snowstorms, and employment in agencies which oversee transportation or emergency management policy. Across these analyses, we find little evidence that treatment effects systematically vary along these dimensions, mitigating concern that the absence of these features in our design limits generalizability.

However, other features of the context surrounding civil servants' relationships with executives cannot be examined through heterogeneous effects. For instance, whereas respondents encounter a stylized executive about whom they have no prior information, civil servants ordinarily interpret an executive's behavior in light of prior information about and experiences with that executive. Respondents also receive the executive's rhetoric directly, even though political appointees and career leaders often mediate communication between executives and civil servants (Heclo, 1977; Resh, 2015). Finally, respondents receive no information about the executive's partisan affiliation, although civil servants ordinarily know their executive's partisanship and shared partisanship can shape how they perceive political leaders (Aberbach and Rockman, 1976; Bolton, De Figueiredo and Lewis, 2021; Lewis, 2008; Resh, 2015). An executive's behavior in a single crisis may therefore matter differently depending on the relationship that already exists between the executive and the civil servants she oversees, and we encourage future research to explore how these and other contextual factors may shape the effect of executives' presentational strategies on civil servants' perceptions.

These qualifications also caution against treating blame claiming as a simple route to stronger bureaucratic support. Claiming responsibility may strengthen civil servants' trust, but shielding an agency from blame when its performance warrants criticism could weaken accountability by signaling that poor performance will not carry consequences. Executives thus confront a basic managerial tension: they need to cultivate the trust required to secure bureaucratic cooperation while also holding civil servants accountable for the outcomes they produce. Their choices may also reach beyond the agency immediately implicated in a crisis. Civil servants elsewhere in government can observe how an executive treats another agency and infer how they might be treated under similar circumstances. The effects of an executive's presentational strategy may therefore extend

generalize to crises in other policy areas. We expect generalizability because many crises in other policy areas, such as protecting the well-being of children in state care or inspecting healthcare facilities, share the core features highlighted by our vignette: residents suffer adverse consequences, political elites and the public seek to assign blame, and the governor employs a presentational strategy to manage her reputation. Future research should assess whether our findings extend to other policy areas.

beyond the immediate crisis and the civil servants directly involved.

When chief executives speak during crises, they speak to more than the public. Their explanations of failure also reach the civil servants responsible for carrying out their priorities. A strategy intended to protect an executive's reputation may come at a cost inside government if it leads civil servants to question whether the executive will support them when circumstances turn difficult. How executives allocate blame can therefore shape not only how they survive a crisis, but also the trust and cooperation they need to govern after it.

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Supplemental Information

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A Preregistration

We preregistered our experimental design through the Open Science Framework on May 18, 2024 (https://osf.io/9v8ga/overview?view_only=1fe35c1e117a4e9787e06a06ad733bd7). When fielding the survey containing the experiment, we deviated from our preregistered design regarding how many individuals in the sampling frame we solicited to participate. We describe this deviation and the rationale behind it here.

In our preregistration, we planned to randomly sample 25% of the 252,317 email addresses we obtained from state employee directories. We chose this approach to balance both power considerations for all of the modules on the survey while not overburdening public employees.¹ The size of our random sample anticipated a response rate of between 5% and 10%, as reported in recent studies utilizing survey experiments with other elite populations (Furnas and LaPira, 2024; Miller, 2022), which would have yielded us approximately 2,600 to 5,200 responses. However, 24 hours after distributing email invitations to the random sample, we observed a response rate of less than 1%, which prompted concern that we would not obtain enough responses to conduct sufficiently powered analyses.² Accordingly, we decided to send email invitations to all state government employees for whom we collected email addresses.

B Experimental Protocol

B.1 Sampling Procedure

The sampling frame for the survey in which the the experiment was embedded was all state government employees in the following nine states whose email addresses were posted publicly in those states' employee directories: Connecticut, Florida, Illinois, Indiana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, North Carolina, Oregon, and Vermont. In the first half of 2023, one of the authors and student research assistants collected emails from these state directories and formatted them into comma-separated files.³

The total number of unique email addresses collected from these nine states is 252,317. We

¹Starting with the initial sample of 252,317 emails across the nine states, we considered two factors that would inform our expected response rate: 1) the expected turnover of state employees between the time the emails were collected in 2023 and the survey was fielded in 2024 and 2) observed response rates in other recent samples of political elites. First, based on reported state turnover rates in our sample, we expected about 16% of employees to no longer be employed by their state, rendering their email address invalid. Second, examining recent survey experiments of political elites, such as congressional staff and federal lobbyists, we anticipated a response rate of between 5% and 10% (Furnas and LaPira, 2024; Miller, 2022).

²While it is difficult to understand systematic reasons for non-response, anecdotally we believe state government employees are less responsive than other recently studied elite populations because they have been trained to be cautious when opening and interacting with emails from unfamiliar sources. Many potential respondents emailed the author who facilitated survey distribution asking for confirmation and/or evidence that the survey invitation was legitimate, and officials from the information technology (IT) offices of several state agencies called the author to assess whether the emails were associated with a cybersecurity risk. Additionally, several potential respondents told the author that policies set by their IT offices prevented them from participating, and others said their IT offices send similar messages to "test" employees' compliance with agency policies. Separately, several potential respondents also told the author that their agency barred employees from completing outside surveys or participating in academic research unless the agency head pre-approved the activities.

³In late 2021, one of the authors surveyed the employee directories of all fifty states to determine whether the state posted the email addresses of its employees publicly. At that time, 25 states provided such information publicly. From those 25 states, one of the authors selected a subset of states where it was most feasible to collect the email addresses given the formatting of each state's directory and such that the subset would demonstrate substantial variation across important state-level characteristics, such as geographic location, partisan control of the governor's office and state legislative chambers, and the relative size of different racial and ethnic groups in the state population.

sent initial email invitations to all unique email addresses between May 31 and June 3, 2024, and sent reminder emails to all respondents who had not yet completed the survey on June 11 and June 18, 2024. Response collection ceased at the end of the day on June 26, 2024, with 2,540 respondents answering at least one of the four outcome questions in the module containing our experiment. Subtracting the 33,213 emails which were deemed invalid once emails were distributed (i.e., those Qualtrics reported as “blocked,” “bounced,” or “failed”), the response rate for this module is approximately 1.2% ($\frac{2,540}{219,103}$).

B.2 Vignette and Question Wording

Upon clicking on the survey link in our email invitation, respondents first reviewed an information sheet detailing the general purpose of the study, their rights as respondents, and procedures in place to protect their privacy. This information told respondents that the purpose of the study was to learn “about how state bureaucrats make decisions, implement policies, and how they interact with other government officials” and previewed that they would be asked to respond to “several hypothetical scenarios about how state bureaucrats make decisions, implement policy, and interact with other government officials.” That the information sheet did not explicitly mention respondents would be asked about their perceptions of a governor’s presentational strategies during a governmental crisis mitigates concerns about selection bias (i.e., respondents who recently experienced a crisis in their own state could not knowingly select into the study at higher rates).

After consenting to participate in the survey and completing a series of pre-treatment questions, respondents were asked to imagine that they work for the department of transportation in another state and were presented with a short vignette describing a recent snowstorm the state experienced that caused significant traffic problems and prompted criticism of the state’s handling of the storm. In this vignette, two facets were independently randomized across respondents: 1) how the governor responded to public criticism of the state’s handling of the storm and 2) information about how well the department of transportation prepared for the storm. The vignette wording and the different treatments associated with each facet are presented below.

B.2.1 Vignette

Imagine the following scenario:

You work for the department of transportation in another state.

A major snowstorm recently hit your state. [DEPARTMENT PREPAREDNESS]. During the course of the storm, major traffic delays and several car accidents occurred on state roadways.

In the immediate aftermath of the storm, legislators, journalists, and members of the public have criticized the state for its handling of the storm.

In a post-storm press conference yesterday, the state’s governor addressed this criticism, saying that [GOVERNOR’S RESPONSE]. The governor pledged to review the state’s snowstorm response protocol to try to minimize traffic problems and car accidents during future storms.

- Treatment Conditions
 - Department Preparedness
 - * CONTROL: *Blank*

- * PREPARED: Your department correctly assessed the severity of the storm and deployed the appropriate number of crews to treat and clear the roads.
- * UNDERPREPARED: Your department underestimated the severity of the storm and deployed fewer crews to treat and clear the roads than was necessary.
- Governor’s Response
 - * CONTROL: “I am sorry that many of our state’s residents were stuck on the roads, but it’s too early to place blame for why the state roadways were in such poor condition.”
 - * BLAME CLAIM: “I am sorry that many of our state’s residents were stuck on the roads. As governor, I am ultimately responsible for the management of state roadways, and I accept blame for this situation.”
 - * BLAME DEFLECT: “I am sorry that many of our state’s residents were stuck on the roads, but the state’s department of transportation is ultimately responsible for the management of state roadways, and they are to blame for this situation.”
 - * BLAME SHARE: “I am sorry that many of our state’s residents were stuck on the roads. As governor, I share responsibility with the state’s department of transportation for the management of state roadways, and I accept some of the blame for this situation.”

B.2.2 Question Wording

- How much trust do you have in this state governor to defend your department when it faces *warranted* criticism?
 - No trust at all
 - A little trust
 - A moderate amount of trust
 - A lot of trust
 - A great deal of trust
- How much trust do you have in this state governor to defend your department when it faces *unwarranted* criticism?
 - No trust at all
 - A little trust
 - A moderate amount of trust
 - A lot of trust
 - A great deal of trust
- How much effort do you expect this state governor to invest in supporting the mission and activities of your department?
 - No effort
 - A little effort
 - Some effort
 - A lot of effort
 - A great deal of effort
- Suppose this state governor asked you to participate in a task force that will review the state governor’s snowstorm response protocol to try to minimize traffic problems during future storms. How likely would you be to participate in the task force?
 - Very unlikely

- Somewhat unlikely
- Somewhat likely
- Very likely

B.3 Respondent Demographic Characteristics

The only systematic information we were able to collect about state government employees in the full sampling frame was their names, email addresses, the states by which they were employed, and the name of the state department/agency for which they worked. Consequently, we lack individual-level data to determine the degree to which our respondents are representative of those in the underlying sampling frame. We present information about survey responsiveness by state in Table SI.1.⁴

For respondents who participated in the module containing our experiment, we collected information on a range of demographic characteristics before they started the module. Table SI.2 provides information about the characteristics of our respondent sample.

Because we lack full information on individual-level demographic characteristics for people in our sampling frame who did not complete the survey, it is difficult to assess how representative our sample is across these characteristics relative to the full population of civil servants in the 9 sampled states. If differences exist between these characteristics for our respondents relative to the sampling frame, it would not affect the internal validity of our study given the independent randomization of treatment facets across respondents (i.e., each respondent randomly assigned a presentational strategy and level of preparedness). However, if differences exist, they may impact external validity if civil servants with different characteristics have systematically different reactions to executives' presentational strategies in a governmental crisis and an imbalance between our respondents and the sampling frame exists for those same characteristics (Coppock, 2019, 615-616). In this case, our sample average treatment effect (SATE), while internally valid, might diverge from the population average treatment effect (PATE)—that which exists among all persons in our sampling frame were we able to observe their reactions to our experiments.

Though we do not have individual-level demographic characteristics for persons in our sampling frame, most of the nine states in our sample publish regular reports about their state government employees, and some of the demographic information we measured among our respondents corresponds with information these reports provide about the characteristics of their state workforces.⁵ This enables us to compare the aggregate demographic characteristics of state employees in each state to the demographic characteristics of respondents from the same state, which provides insight into how well our respondents reflect the broader sampling frame. While useful, these comparisons have a few inherent limitations. First, because each state measures and reports different information about its workers, our points of comparison vary across states; for instance, only 6 of 9 states report information about employees' race/ethnicity. Second, since the questions we used to measure respondents' demographic characteristics are sometimes different from how states reported on conceptually similar information about their employees, comparisons are not one-to-one mappings; as an example, the bin sizes we used when asking respondents how many years they have worked for the state government differed from those used by most states in our sample, making comparisons difficult. Third, given our low response rate, our measures of state-level demographic characteris-

⁴Because departments/agencies are inconsistently named across states, we are not able to construct a similarly compact representation of response rates across departments/agencies.

⁵We were not able to identify official government reports from Indiana that provided demographic characteristics for its employees. For the other eight states, we used the official report issued closest to when our survey was fielded, preferring reports issued before our survey when possible.

tics are likely to be highly variable compared to those reported for the full population of workers in each state (e.g., our measures of demographic characteristics of state employees in Vermont are based on 89 respondents, compared to the 3,645 in our sampling frame). Given these challenges, some difference between our respondents' characteristics and those reported by the states for which they work is expected.

In Table SI.3 we compare the demographic characteristics of our respondents in each state with those reported by the state in its official report on state government personnel.⁶ We generally observe similarity with respect to gender, as both our respondents and the state workforces reflect nearly even proportions of men and women albeit with slightly more women. We also note that across states, White workers tend to outnumber those from other racial and ethnic groups among both our respondents and in the state workforces, though Whites (non-Whites) are better (worse) represented among our respondents as a matter of proportions in some states (e.g., for Florida, our respondents are 68.0% White and 15.1% Black or African-American, but the full population of Florida state workers is 52.8% White and 28.3% Black or African-American).

The main recurring difference we note across states is that our respondents tend to be older and have more years of experience working for the state government than do the corresponding population of state workers—two characteristics that are correlated, as those with longer tenures in state government are necessarily older than many with shorter tenures.⁷ This imbalance may suggest that our respondents are more well-socialized into the cultures of their state government, such that they have clearer expectations for the “public service bargain” that governs politician-bureaucrat relationships and may react differently to violations of that bargain (Hood and Lodge, 2006). Differently, because civil servants with managerial responsibilities and closer to agency leadership and the governor tend to be older and have more years of experience, our respondents might be more sensitive to and react more strongly to the stylized governor's presentational strategies. Since the characteristics related to these imbalances may be indicative of heterogeneous treatment

⁶The official state reports used to make these comparisons are: “Post-Retirement Tsunami: Trends in Representation and Pay Equity in CT State Government,” Connecticut Office of the State Comptroller, June 2024, <https://osc.ct.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Post-Retirement-Surge-Representation-and-Pay-Equity-2.pdf>; “State of Florida: Annual Workforce Report, FY 2023-2024,” Florida Department of Management Services, August 14, 2025, <https://dms-media.ccplatform.net/content/download/434221/file/2023%202024%20Annual%20Workforce%20Report%208.14.25%20-%20FINAL.pdf>; “Workforce Data Report,” Illinois Department of Central Management Services, March 30, 2025, https://cms.illinois.gov/content/dam/soi/en/web/cms/documents/CMS_Personnel_2025%20Workforce%20Report_260203.pdf; “2024 Personnel Almanac,” Nebraska Department of Administrative Services, June 2024, <https://govdocs.nebraska.gov/epubs/P2000/B004-2024.pdf>; “Fiscal Year 2024 Annual Report,” New Hampshire Department of Administrative Services, https://www.das.nh.gov/hr/documents/AnnualReports/2024_DOP_ANNUAL_REPORT-V1.pdf; “Current State Employee Statistics,” North Carolina Office of State Human Resources, April 2024, <https://web.archive.org/web/20240531140609/https://oshr.nc.gov/work-nc/employee-statistics/current-state-employee-statistics>; “Affirmative Action Report,” Oregon Department of Administrative Services, March 5, 2025, <https://www.oregon.gov/das/strategy/Documents/affirmative-action-report-2023-2025.pdf>; “Workforce Report: Fiscal Year 2024,” Vermont Department of Human Resources, January 13, 2025, <https://legislature.vermont.gov/assets/Legislative-Reports/Workforce-Report-Fiscal-Year-2024.pdf>.

⁷For the one state that reports state employees' levels of educational attainment (North Carolina), we also observe an imbalance where respondents have higher levels of educational attainment than does the full population of state workers. This makes sense as people with higher levels of education tend to be older, as it takes additional years to complete more advanced degrees; thus, this imbalance is related to the imbalance concerning age and years of experience working for the state government. Because we only have indicators for educational attainment from one state, we focus our discussion here on age and years of experience working for the state government, noting that the implications of older and more experienced civil servants over-represented in our sample are likely similar of having individuals with higher levels of educational attainment over-represented. We also repeat the heterogeneous effect analysis replacing respondents' years of experience with level of educational attainment (not shown), which yields a similar lack of evidence of heterogeneous effects.

effects, which may lead our SATEs to diverge from the PATEs, we assess the presence of these heterogeneous effects in Section C.

Finally, we note that while we can make comparisons between the demographic characteristics of our respondents compared to the sampling frame for this small number of observed characteristics, we cannot make similar comparisons for unobserved characteristics, such as the degree of managerial responsibility an individual has or whether the individual recently experienced a crisis in which their governor used a presentational strategy that may have implicated their agency. Consequently, it is important to keep in mind that our SATEs may not perfectly reflect the PATEs we seek to draw inferences about to the extent that imbalance may exist in these kinds of unobserved characteristics if those characteristics also prompt heterogeneous treatment effects.

Table SI.1: Sampling Frame Response Rates by State

State	# respondents	# employees invited to participate	Response rate
Connecticut	191	11,929	1.6%
Florida	435	68,178	0.6%
Illinois	29	1,840	1.6%
Indiana	166	27,168	0.6%
Nebraska	322	12,701	2.5%
New Hampshire	22	8,898	0.2%
North Carolina	536	48,283	1.1%
Oregon	750	36,460	2.1%
Vermont	89	3,645	2.4%
TOTAL	2,540	219,103	1.2%

Table SI.2: Demographic Characteristics of Survey Respondents

Characteristic	# (%) of respondents
<u>Gender</u>	
Man	1150 (45.3%)
Woman	1334 (52.5%)
Something else/other	26 (1.0%)
Prefer not to say	26 (1.0%)
NA	4 (0.2%)
<u>Age</u>	
18-29	134 (5.3%)
30-49	1118 (44.0%)
50-64	1096 (43.1%)
65 or older	191 (7.5%)
NA	1 (0.0%)
<u>Income</u>	
Less than \$25,000	7 (0.3%)
\$25,000-\$49,999	216 (8.5%)
\$50,000-\$74,999	463 (18.2%)

Characteristic	# (%) of respondents
\$75,000-\$99,999	492 (19.4%)
\$100,000-\$199,999	1037 (40.8%)
\$200,000 or more	306 (12.0%)
NA	19 (0.7%)
<u>Education</u>	
Some high school, or less	2 (0.1%)
High school graduate or GED	81 (3.2%)
Some college, no 4-year degree	364 (14.3%)
College graduate	931 (36.7%)
Post-graduate degree	1158 (45.6%)
NA	4 (0.2%)
<u>Race</u>	
American Indian or Alaska Native	17 (0.7%)
American Indian or other Pacific Islander	10 (0.4%)
Asian	65 (2.6%)
Black or African-American	222 (8.7%)
American Indian or other Pacific Islander	5 (0.2%)
White	2073 (81.6%)
Other	132 (5.2%)
NA	16 (0.6%)
<u>Hispanic</u>	
Yes	165 (6.5%)
No	2340 (92.1%)
Prefer not to say	30 (1.2%)
NA	5 (0.2%)
<u>Party Identification</u>	
Strong Democrat	731 (28.8%)
Not a very strong Democrat	358 (14.1%)
Lean Democrat	306 (12.0%)
Independent	251 (9.9%)
Lean Republican	152 (6.0%)
Not a very strong Republican	216 (8.5%)
Strong Republican	287 (11.3%)
Other/NA	239 (9.4%)
<u>Ideology</u>	
Very liberal	272 (10.7%)
Liberal	629 (24.8%)
Slightly liberal	322 (12.7%)
Moderate	635 (25.0%)
Slightly conservative	202 (8.0%)
Conservative	364 (14.3%)
Very conservative	106 (4.2%)
NA	10 (0.4%)
<u># Years Working for</u>	
<u>State Gov.</u>	
Less than 5 years	615 (24.2%)

Characteristic	# (%) of respondents
5-10 years	721 (28.4%)
11-15 years	312 (12.3%)
16-20 years	296 (11.7%)
More than 20 years	593 (23.3%)
NA	3 (0.1%)
<u>Frequency of Performing Management Tasks</u>	
Never	997 (39.3%)
Not very frequently	483 (19.0%)
Somewhat frequently	325 (12.8%)
Very frequently	731 (28.8%)
NA	4 (0.2%)
<u>Job Selection Method</u>	
Appointed by elected official	85 (3.3%)
Hired/promoted through civil service system	2066 (81.3%)
Other	386 (15.2%)
NA	3 (0.1%)

Table SI.3: Comparison of Demographic Characteristics of Respondents to Full Population of State-Level Government Workers in Their States

	% of respondents	% of state workers
<u>CONNECTICUT</u>		
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	46.1%	52%
Male	52.4%	48%
Other/NA	1.5%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
Asian, Non-Hispanic	4.2%	4%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	8.9%	20%
Hispanic	13.0%	13%
White, Non-Hispanic	69.1%	63%
Other, Non-Hispanic	4.6%	-
<u>FLORIDA</u>		
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	55.4%	57.9%
Male	43.4%	42.0%
Other/NA	1.1%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	15.1%	28.3%
Hispanic	10.3%	13.7%
White, Non-Hispanic	68.0%	52.8%
Other, Non-Hispanic	6.4%	5.1%
<u>ILLINOIS</u>		
<u>Age</u>		
Median/Mode	Modal bin is 50-64 (65.6%)	Median of 47 years, 4 months
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>		
Median/Mode	Modal bin is more than 20 years (37.9%)	All but one agency has a median of at least 7 years, 2 months (only reported at agency-level)
<u>NEBRASKA</u>		
<u>Age</u>		
18-29	6.5%	17.5%
30-49	42.5%	44.1%
50-64	41.0%	32.7%
65 and over	9.9%	5.7%
<u>Gender</u>		

	% of respondents	% of state workers
Female	53.7%	54%
Male	43.8%	46%
Other/NA	2.5%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
Asian, Non-Hispanic	1.2%	2%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	4.7%	4%
Hispanic	5.6%	5%
White, Non-Hispanic	82.6%	85.2%
Other, Non-Hispanic	5.8%	3%
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>		
Mean/Mode	Modal respondent has 10 or fewer (57.5%)	Average of 9.5
<u>NEW HAMPSHIRE</u>		
<u>Age</u>		
18-29	0.0%	10.8%
30-49	63.6%	44.2%
50-64	22.7%	39.3%
65 and over	13.6%	5.6%
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	50.0%	54.5%
Male	50.0%	45.5%
Other/NA	0.0%	-
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>		
Less than 5 years	18.2%	40.6%
5 years or more	81.8%	59.4%
<u>NORTH CAROLINA</u>		
<u>Age</u>		
18-29	4.7%	12%
30-49	42.2%	45%
50 and over	53.0%	42%
NA	0.2%	-
<u>Education</u>		
Less than high school	0.0%	5%
High school/some college but no 4-year degree	15.1%	33%
Four-year college degree	33.2%	28%
Post-graduate degree	51.3%	13%
Other/NA	0.4%	1%
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	50.9%	53%

	% of respondents	% of state workers
Male	46.8%	47%
Other/NA	2.2%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
American Indian/Alaskan/Pacific Islander, Non-Hispanic	1.0%	2.0%
Asian, Non-Hispanic	2.4%	3%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	15.5%	30%
Hispanic	2.2%	4%
White, Non-Hispanic	76.1%	60%
Other, Non-Hispanic/NA	2.8%	2%
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>		
Less than 5 years	19.0%	31%
5 years or more	80.8%	69%
NA	0.2%	-
<u>OREGON</u>		
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	53.7%	57%
Male	43.2%	43%
Other/NA	3.0%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
American Indian, Non-Hispanic	0.9%	2.2%
American Indian or Pacific Islander, Non-Hispanic	0.9%	0.7%
Asian, Non-Hispanic	3.0%	4.5%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	2.4%	2.7%
Hispanic	7.1%	10.6%
White, Non-Hispanic	82.0%	72.2%
Other, Non-Hispanic	3.4%	7.0%
<u>VERMONT</u>		
<u>Age</u>		
Mean/mode	Mean of 44.9 years old	Modal respondent in 50-64 years old bin (47.2%)
<u>Gender</u>		
Female	49.4%	52.2%
Male	48.3%	47.8%
Other/NA	2.2%	-
<u>Race/Ethnicity</u>		
American Indian, Non-Hispanic	1.1%	0.4%
American Indian or Pacific Islander, Non-Hispanic	0.0%	0.1%
Asian, Non-Hispanic	0.0%	1.3%
Black or African-American, Non-Hispanic	1.1%	1.5%

	% of respondents	% of state workers
Hispanic	1.1%	1.8%
White, Non-Hispanic	89.9%	93.7%
Other, Non-Hispanic	6.7%	1.2%
<u>Years of Experience in State Government</u>		
Less than 5 years	9.0%	38.3%
5 years or more	91.0%	61.7%

Values in first column represent proportion of respondents with each demographic characteristic for each state. Values in second column drawn from official state reports on their state government workforce issued close to their fielding of our survey in May-June 2024. Indiana is excluded as we could not locate any official state reports on their state government workforce that provided demographic information. Where our survey and the state reports differed in terms of potential values for each characteristic (e.g., different sized years of experience bins), we collapsed values to make both data sources as comparable as possible. Some characteristics may not sum to 100% due to rounding.

C Empirical Analysis

We present the tabular results of the models presented in Figures 2 and 3 in Tables SI.4 and SI.5, respectively.

The remaining analyses presented in this section help us address concerns about effect heterogeneity:

- **Years of Experience Working in State Government:** In Supplemental Information Section B.3, we note that compared to the full populations of state-level civil servants in the states from which our respondents are drawn, our respondents tend to be older and have more years of experience. While this imbalance does not have implications for internal validity, it could lead to different sample average treatment effects (SATEs) than the population average treatment effects (PATEs) about which we seek to draw inferences if civil servants of differing ages and years of experience prompt heterogeneous responses to our treatments.

To explore these possible heterogeneous effects, we repeated our main analyses and included an interaction between our five-point scale indicating the number of years respondents have worked for the state government (recoded 0 to 4) with our treatment indicators. Looking across the models in Table SI.6, we see that for three of our four outcomes, we find no evidence of heterogeneous effects. For respondents’ trust that the governor will defend their department from warranted criticism, we find that more experienced civil servants offer somewhat more positive evaluations of the executive than less experienced civil servants when told the executive claimed *or* deflected blame. The interactive effect associated with blame deflection may suggest that civil servants who are more thoroughly socialized into the politician-bureaucrat “public service bargain” existing in that state may expect that executives will deflect blame when crises arise, such that a single instance of blame deflection does not damage their trust in the executive as much as a less experienced civil servant who does not share those expectations (Hood and Lodge, 2006). Differently, the heterogeneous effect associated with blame claiming may reflect that more experienced civil servants have low expectations for executives claiming blame, so in the rare instances it happens they offer more positive rewards than their less experienced colleagues. However, we are unable to probe the mechanisms underlying these effects further, and we encourage future research to explore how

civil servants' length of experience and socialization affects how they interpret actions and words from elected executives.

While we observe these heterogeneous effects for this one outcome—trust that the governor will defend the department from warranted criticism—we argue that these results on the whole provide little evidence for a more general interactive effect that would lead our SATEs to diverge substantially from our PATEs. First, more experienced civil servants still evaluate the governor who deflects blame as less trustworthy for this one outcome, even though the magnitude of the effect is smaller than it is for less seasoned colleagues. Second, this outcome is the one most clearly tied to the episode described by the vignette, and that it does not bleed over to other more downstream outcomes suggests it may be context-bound; while more experienced respondents lower their trust that the governor will defend them from criticism when it is warranted less than their more junior colleagues, the treatment does not prompt them to think the governor is less likely to go out of her way to blame them for outcomes outside their control, does not make them less likely to exert additional effort on behalf of the executive, and does not change their perception of the governor's broader support of the department. Thus, while this heterogeneous effect emerges, it does not reflect broader implications for respondents' trust in the governor.

- **Frequency of Performing Management Tasks:** In Supplemental Information Section B.3, we mention that respondents who are older and have more years of experience in government are more likely to hold positions that involve management responsibility that are closer to the elected executive and his political appointees in their agency's hierarchy, which may lead them to be naturally more attentive to the executive's rhetoric and thus respond differently to our treatments. Though we cannot observe which of the individuals in our sampling frame who did not respond to our survey hold management positions, such that we do not know if our sample is imbalanced on this dimension, the imbalance we do observe for age and years of experience suggest imbalance may exist, prompting us to explore the existence of heterogeneous effects driven by respondents' management responsibilities.

We assess the presence of these heterogeneous effects by interacting our treatment indicators with a dichotomous indicator for whether respondents indicated in a pre-treatment question

of our survey that they “somewhat” or “very frequently” engaged in management tasks (1), such as directing and coordinating employees who report to them, or that they “never” or “not very frequently” engaged in such tasks (0). Our results, presented in Table SI.7, provide no evidence of heterogeneous effects related to respondents’ own management experience.

- **Degree of Executive Control over Civil Servants:** In our Conclusion, we mention that the degree of control executives can assert over civil servants in a given political institution may condition those civil servants’ reactions to executives’ presentational strategies; for instance, if job protections in a state are weak, civil servants may react less negatively to an executive deflecting blame to their agency relative to civil servants in a state with stronger protections because they are more accustomed to the executives interfering in their work for political gain. To assess the plausibility of this dynamic, we estimate separate models for each state and compare results across states depending on the job protections civil servants there enjoy. According to the Commonwealth Foundation, of the states in our sample Florida, Indiana, and North Carolina have weak job protections for public employees, while the remaining states in our sample have markedly stronger levels of job protections; thus, we want to assess whether the treatment effects we recover in these three states are substantially different than those in the other six states.⁸

Looking across Tables SI.8-SI.11, we observe little evidence of systematic variation in treatment effects across these two groups of states. For each group, the coefficient estimates for blame deflection are consistently negative and have a similar range of magnitudes; for instance, for trust that the governor invest in the department, the magnitudes of the effect of blame deflection range between -0.24 and -0.63 among the three states with weaker job protections and -0.20 and -0.94 among the six states with stronger protections. The degree of variation in the estimated coefficients for blame claiming and blame sharing are also similar when making comparisons across these two groups of states.

⁸(Osborne, David R. and Andrew Holman. 2024. “The Battle for Worker Freedom: Grading State Public Sector Labor Laws.” *Commonwealth Foundation*. 4th Edition. <https://www.commonwealthfoundation.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/50-State-Public-Sector-Labor-Laws-paper.pdf>.) The Commonwealth Foundation is a conservative think tank based in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania. While the tone of the report we draw from is ideologically charged (i.e., states with strong job protections for public employees are graded “F” while those with weak protections are graded “A+” or “A”), the information on which they draw to provide state-level assessments of public employee job protections are objective (e.g., one element of their grading scale is whether collective bargaining for public employees is legal).

- **Experience with Snowstorms:** In the Conclusion, we note that civil servants’ experience with major snowstorms may condition their responses to our stimuli. While all of the states in our sample are at annual risk for the kinds of major snowstorms our vignette describes (see Footnote 11 in the main text), some states have experience with more frequent and severe snowstorms. Consequently, respondents from different states may have varied mental models of what snowstorms and snowstorm preparedness look like, and this variation may prompt respondents to react differently to our stimuli. Of the states in our sample, Florida experiences distinctly less snow than the others, though snowstorms can and do impact Florida and can exact harmful consequences in part due to their infrequency.⁹ Respondents from Florida may have either responded less strongly to our treatments because our vignette felt less realistic given the relative infrequency of snow in Florida, or they may have responded more strongly because when major snowstorms impact Florida they can cause significant damage and inconvenience because the state has less experience responding to them.

However, looking across Tables SI.8-SI.11, we observe little evidence of systematic variation in treatment effects for Florida versus the other eight states. For instance, for trust that the government will defend the department against warranted criticism, the negative coefficient for Blame Deflect (-0.39) is of similar magnitude of that for Connecticut (-0.42) and is larger than that for New Hampshire (-0.20), and the positive coefficient for Blame Claim (0.34) is again of similar magnitude of that for Connecticut (0.27) and is larger than several other states (e.g., 0.17 for Nebraska, 0.04 for North Carolina).

- **Experience with Transportation Policy:** As we mention in the Conclusion section, our vignette’s focus on a major snowstorm that impacts state roadways could be more relatable for respondents with experience with transportation or emergency management policy, such that those respondents may react more strongly to our treatments than might other respondents who do not have experience with this kind of governmental crisis.

To evaluate this possibility, we referred to the names of the departments/agencies each of our respondents work in and created an indicator that takes on a value of “1” if the respondent

⁹(Dolce, Chris. “All 50 States Have Seen Snow This Winter and Some Southern Cities Have Topped Northern Ones.” *The Weather Channel*, January 23, 2025, <https://weather.com/storms/winter/news/2025-01-22-50-states-snowfall-winter-southern-cities-top-northern-cities>)

works for a department/agency that focuses on transportation or emergency management and “0” otherwise; 272 (10.7%) of our respondents were coded as working in departments/agencies focusing on these policy areas. We then interacted our treatment indicators with this dichotomous indicator. The results of these analyses, presented in Table SI.12, provide no evidence of heterogeneous effects, as none of the coefficients on the interaction terms are statistically distinguishable from zero.

C.1 Tabular Results of Models in Main Paper

Table SI.4: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Perceptions of Governor

	Gov. Defend from Unwarranted Criticism	Gov. Defend from Warranted Criticism	Gov. Invest Effort in Department	R Willing to Serve on Task Force
Intercept	2.80* (0.05)	2.64* (0.05)	3.18* (0.05)	3.30* (0.04)
Blame Claim	0.17* (0.06)	0.23* (0.06)	0.16* (0.06)	0.08 (0.05)
Blame Deflect	-0.79* (0.06)	-0.59* (0.06)	-0.45* (0.06)	-0.15* (0.05)
Blame Share	0.02 (0.06)	0.09 (0.06)	-0.01 (0.06)	0.07 (0.05)
Num. obs.	2534	2532	2534	2538

This table corresponds to the results presented in Figure 2. Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Dependent variable for each variable is denoted in the model heading. The omitted category for the governor’s presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm.

Table SI.5: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Perceptions of Governor, Conditioned by Preparedness

	Gov. Defend from Unwarranted Criticism	Gov. Defend from Warranted Criticism	Gov. Invest Effort in Department	R Willing to Serve on Task Force
Intercept	2.90*	2.75*	3.34*	3.37*
	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.07)
Blame Claim	0.10	0.17	0.07	0.00
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.09)
Blame Deflect	-0.97*	-0.76*	-0.66*	-0.27*
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.09)
Blame Share	0.05	-0.02	-0.07	0.03
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.09)
Department Prepared	-0.11	-0.13	-0.20	-0.06
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.09)
Department Prepared	-0.11	-0.13	-0.20	-0.06
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.09)
Claim:	-0.02	-0.00	0.02	0.08
Prepared	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.12)
Deflect:	0.04	0.04	0.10	0.07
Prepared	(0.16)	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.12)
Share:	-0.21	-0.02	-0.07	-0.01
Prepared	(0.16)	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.13)
Claim:	0.27	0.18	0.26	0.15
Underprepared	(0.16)	(0.16)	(0.16)	(0.13)
Deflect:	0.50*	0.49*	0.54*	0.28*
Underprepared	(0.16)	(0.15)	(0.16)	(0.13)
Share:	0.13	0.35*	0.24	0.14
Underprepared	(0.16)	(0.15)	(0.16)	(0.13)
Num. obs.	2534	2532	2534	2538

This table corresponds to the results presented in Figure 3. Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Dependent variable for each variable is denoted in the model heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. The omitted category for the department's preparedness is the Control condition, in which no information is provided about whether the department adequately prepared for the snowstorm.

C.2 Alternative Specifications

Table SI.6: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Bureaucratic Perceptions, Conditional on Years of Experience Working for the State Government

	Gov. Defend from Unwarranted Criticism	Gov. Defend from Warranted Criticism	Gov. Invest Effort in Department	R Willing to Serve on Task Force
Intercept	2.80* (0.07)	2.72* (0.07)	3.19* (0.06)	3.29* (0.05)
Blame Claim	0.09 (0.10)	0.08 (0.10)	0.11 (0.09)	0.05 (0.07)
Blame Deflect	-0.86* (0.10)	-0.77* (0.10)	-0.50* (0.09)	-0.15* (0.07)
Blame Share	-0.09 (0.10)	-0.02 (0.10)	-0.06 (0.09)	0.05 (0.07)
Years of Experience	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.05 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.09)	0.03 (0.07)
Blame Claim: Years of Experience	0.04 (0.04)	0.08* (0.04)	0.12 (0.13)	0.05 (0.10)
Blame Deflect: Years of Experience	0.04 (0.04)	0.10* (0.04)	0.11 (0.13)	-0.00 (0.10)
Blame Share: Years of Experience	0.06 (0.04)	0.06 (0.04)	0.13 (0.13)	0.04 (0.10)
Num. obs.	2531	2529	2531	2535

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Dependent variable for each variable is denoted in the model heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. Respondents' reports of their years of service working for the state government are coded as a 0-4 scale, where 0 represents "less than 5 years" and 4 represents "more than 20 years" (see Table SI.2 for full list of response options).

Table SI.7: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Bureaucratic Perceptions, Conditional on Management Experience

	Gov. Defend from Unwarranted Criticism	Gov. Defend from Warranted Criticism	Gov. Invest Effort in Department	R Willing to Serve on Task Force
Intercept	2.74* (0.06)	2.60* (0.06)	3.16* (0.06)	3.23* (0.05)
Blame Claim	0.21* (0.08)	0.26* (0.08)	0.19* (0.08)	0.12 (0.07)
Blame Deflect	-0.75* (0.08)	-0.60* (0.08)	-0.50* (0.08)	-0.20* (0.07)
Blame Share	-0.04 (0.08)	0.05 (0.08)	-0.05 (0.08)	0.07 (0.07)
Management Experience	0.13 (0.09)	0.10 (0.09)	0.05 (0.09)	0.18* (0.07)
Blame Claim: Management Experience	-0.10 (0.13)	-0.08 (0.13)	-0.07 (0.13)	-0.11 (0.10)
Blame Deflect: Management Experience	-0.08 (0.13)	0.03 (0.13)	0.13 (0.13)	0.12 (0.10)
Blame Share: Management Experience	0.15 (0.13)	0.10 (0.13)	0.08 (0.13)	-0.02 (0.10)
Num. obs.	2530	2528	2530	2534

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Dependent variable for each variable is denoted in the model heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. Respondents are coded as having management experience (1) if they indicated that they "somewhat" or "very frequently" engage in management tasks as part of their jobs, such as directing and coordinating employees who report to them; respondents who said that they "never" or "not very frequently" engaged in management tasks were coded as not having management experience (0).

Table SI.8: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Trust the Governor Will Shield Department from Unwarranted Criticism, By State

	CT	FL	IL	IN	NE	NH	NC	OR	VT
Intercept	2.79*	2.78*	5.00*	2.69*	2.65*	2.40*	2.96*	2.77*	2.81*
	(0.18)	(0.12)	(0.86)	(0.17)	(0.12)	(0.54)	(0.10)	(0.08)	(0.22)
Blame Claim	0.39	0.29	-1.60	0.18	0.09	0.93	-0.01	0.16	0.36
	(0.24)	(0.17)	(1.01)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.73)	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.32)
Blame Deflect	-0.62*	-0.47*	-2.50*	-0.69*	-0.76*	-0.40	-1.01*	-0.90*	-1.02*
	(0.27)	(0.17)	(0.94)	(0.25)	(0.19)	(0.76)	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.30)
Blame Share	0.12	0.10	-2.08*	0.02	0.21	1.10	-0.26	-0.02	0.46
	(0.25)	(0.17)	(0.92)	(0.27)	(0.17)	(0.73)	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.29)
Num. obs.	190	435	29	166	321	22	534	748	89

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Each model contains only respondents from the state indicated by the column heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. The omitted category for the department's preparedness is the Control condition, in which no information is provided about whether the department adequately prepared for the snowstorm.

Table SI.9: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Trust the Governor Will Shield Department from Warranted Criticism, By State

	CT	FL	IL	IN	NE	NH	NC	OR	VT
Intercept	2.70*	2.69*	4.00*	2.45*	2.48*	2.20*	2.78*	2.60*	2.62*
	(0.18)	(0.12)	(0.74)	(0.15)	(0.11)	(0.48)	(0.10)	(0.08)	(0.23)
Blame Claim	0.27	0.34*	-0.60	0.65*	0.17	0.60	0.04	0.18	0.44
	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.87)	(0.21)	(0.16)	(0.68)	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.34)
Blame Deflect	-0.42	-0.39*	-1.40	-0.58*	-0.54*	-0.20	-0.65*	-0.72*	-0.91*
	(0.26)	(0.17)	(0.81)	(0.23)	(0.17)	(0.68)	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.31)
Blame Share	0.09	0.10	-0.83	0.26	0.36*	0.80	-0.15	0.00	0.50
	(0.25)	(0.16)	(0.80)	(0.24)	(0.16)	(0.65)	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.31)
Num. obs.	191	434	29	166	320	21	534	748	89

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Each model contains only respondents from the state indicated by the column heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. The omitted category for the department's preparedness is the Control condition, in which no information is provided about whether the department adequately prepared for the snowstorm.

Table SI.10: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Trust the Governor Will Invest in Department, By State

	CT	FL	IL	IN	NE	NH	NC	OR	VT
Intercept	3.23*	3.26*	3.50*	3.14*	3.05*	2.80*	3.21*	3.16*	3.19*
	(0.17)	(0.11)	(0.77)	(0.16)	(0.12)	(0.50)	(0.10)	(0.09)	(0.20)
Blame Claim	0.15	0.40*	0.50	0.20	0.00	0.87	-0.02	0.17	0.31
	(0.23)	(0.16)	(0.91)	(0.23)	(0.18)	(0.68)	(0.14)	(0.12)	(0.30)
Blame Deflect	-0.23	-0.24	-0.90	-0.63*	-0.45*	-0.20	-0.49*	-0.49*	-0.94*
	(0.25)	(0.15)	(0.85)	(0.25)	(0.19)	(0.71)	(0.14)	(0.12)	(0.28)
Blame Share	0.25	0.05	-0.00	-0.18	0.04	0.87	-0.17	-0.07	0.16
	(0.24)	(0.15)	(0.84)	(0.26)	(0.18)	(0.68)	(0.14)	(0.12)	(0.27)
Num. obs.	190	434	29	166	321	22	535	748	89

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Each model contains only respondents from the state indicated by the column heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. The omitted category for the department's preparedness is the Control condition, in which no information is provided about whether the department adequately prepared for the snowstorm.

Table SI.11: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Willingness to Serve on Task Force, By State

	CT	FL	IL	IN	NE	NH	NC	OR	VT
Intercept	3.35*	3.32*	3.50*	3.08*	3.24*	2.80*	3.24*	3.41*	3.52*
	(0.14)	(0.09)	(0.65)	(0.13)	(0.10)	(0.46)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.16)
Blame Claim	-0.13	-0.04	-0.10	0.31	0.05	0.37	0.18	0.07	-0.02
	(0.18)	(0.13)	(0.76)	(0.18)	(0.14)	(0.62)	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.24)
Blame Deflect	-0.20	-0.11	-0.00	-0.03	-0.08	0.60	-0.13	-0.32*	-0.11
	(0.20)	(0.13)	(0.71)	(0.19)	(0.15)	(0.65)	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.22)
Blame Share	-0.02	0.03	0.17	0.27	0.03	1.20	0.04	0.04	0.01
	(0.19)	(0.13)	(0.70)	(0.20)	(0.14)	(0.62)	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.22)
Num. obs.	191	435	29	166	321	22	535	750	89

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Each model contains only respondents from the state indicated by the column heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. The omitted category for the department's preparedness is the Control condition, in which no information is provided about whether the department adequately prepared for the snowstorm.

Table SI.12: Effect of Gubernatorial Presentational Strategies on Bureaucratic Perceptions, Conditional on Transportation Policy Experience

	Gov. Defend from Unwarranted Criticism	Gov. Defend from Warranted Criticism	Gov. Invest Effort in Department	R Willing to Serve on Task Force
Intercept	2.77* (0.05)	2.60* (0.05)	3.16* (0.05)	3.30* (0.04)
Blame Claim	0.20* (0.07)	0.26* (0.07)	0.15* (0.07)	0.06 (0.05)
Blame Deflect	-0.79* (0.07)	-0.59* (0.07)	-0.45* (0.07)	-0.15* (0.05)
Blame Share	-0.01 (0.07)	0.07 (0.07)	-0.05 (0.07)	0.04 (0.05)
Transportation Policy Experience	0.25 (0.15)	0.31* (0.15)	0.13 (0.15)	-0.02 (0.12)
Blame Claim:Trans. Experience	-0.29 (0.20)	-0.27 (0.20)	0.03 (0.20)	0.09 (0.16)
Blame Deflect:Trans. Experience	-0.01 (0.21)	0.02 (0.21)	0.04 (0.21)	-0.01 (0.17)
Blame Share:Trans. Experience	0.26 (0.21)	0.17 (0.20)	0.39 (0.21)	0.27 (0.17)
Num. obs.	2534	2532	2534	2538

Models are estimated with ordinary least squares regression. * denotes coefficient estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $p < 0.05$ level (two-tailed). Dependent variable for each variable is denoted in the model heading. The omitted category for the governor's presentational strategy is the Control condition, in which the governor makes no comment about who is to blame for the poor handling of the snowstorm. Respondents are considered to have transportation policy experience for the purpose of this experiment if they work for a department/agency that focuses on transportation or emergency management.

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